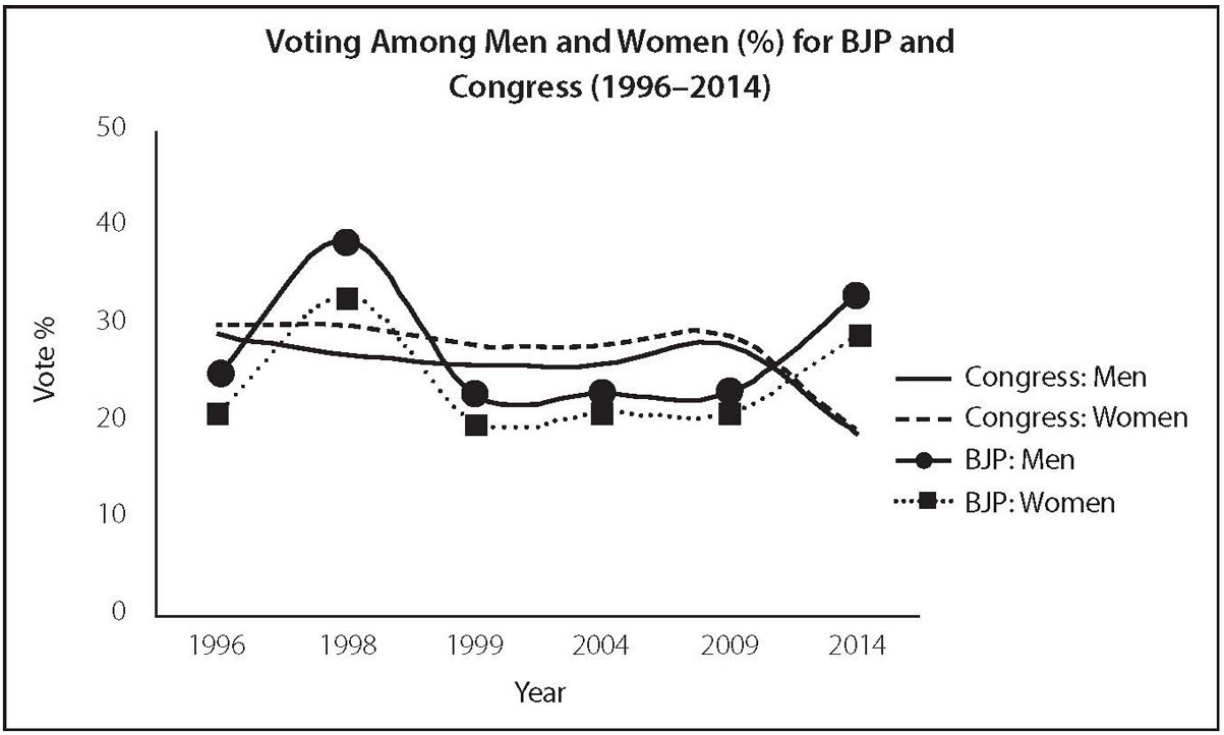
3 point disadvantage among women voters as compared to the Congress Party'. This state of affairs was 'broadly similar to the situation in the United States, where women have historically leaned more toward the Democratic Party than the Republican Party.'[33]

Yet, by 2018, the BJP had 'largely shed its gender disadvantage'. As Rukmini S. pointed out, the CSDS-Lokniti's May 2018 survey found that virtually all of the modest increase in the BJP's vote share between 2014 and 2018 came from women voters. In May 2014, 33 per cent of men and 29 per cent of women preferred the BJP (see Figure 17.2). Four years later, male support remained at the same level, but women's support had risen to 31 per cent. Many BJP leaders attributed this rise to the government's numerous welfare schemes.[34] This process reached its culmination in 2019 with more women voting for the BJP than men.

Figure 17.2: BJP's Gender Disadvantage (1996–2014), Which Was Overturned in 2019



Source: Lokniti-CSDS NES data. Quoted in Rukmini S., 'Women Voters Make Political Parties Take Notice', Seminar, *No. 720, August 2019, http://www.india-seminar.com/2019/720/720_rukmini_s.htm*